The Jealous Sun and His Beloved Moon

By Folk tale from Papua New Guinea - Anonymous

INTRODUCTION

Storytelling is common to every culture. Most people enjoy listening to stories. Storytellers have catered for the need for a 'good story' since the beginning of civilization. A folktale is a popular story that was passed on in spoken form, from one generation to the next. Usually the author is unknown and there are often many versions of the tale. The Jealous Sun and His Beloved Moon is a folktale that originated in Paupa New Guinea and is often used to explain why some members of this varied culture refuse to look too long at the moon.

While walking in the forest one day, Aruako discovered a beautiful girl alone in a pond, taking her bath. Her grass skirt lay folded near the pond's edge. He sat down on it to watch her. Her lovely wet skin shimmered in the sunlight. Underneath the pond's clear surface, her body moved as gracefully as a mermaid's.

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She looked like a woman, but she was actually the spirit of the moon.

The moon woman spied Aruako sitting on the bank. "I remember you," she said. "You dug me like a root from the side of my mother earth." Then she threw back her head and laughed! "You poor thing, burning with desire! You want to marry me. But I warn you – you will die! I am a spirit and you are a man. We can never marry."

Aruako listened but paid no attention to her words. They were as light as butterfly wings on his cheeks. He was enchanted by her radiant beauty. How she glowed with light!

The moon maiden watched Aruako watching her. "I know what you're thinking," she said. "This pond is filled with magic. I come here each day to wash myself and restore my brightness. You had better get those reckless thoughts out of your head, you foolish man. I am betrothed to the sun. Only he can marry me." She stared at him with her dark, liquid eyes.

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"Wait," pleaded Aruako. "Listen to me. I unearthed you. I found you and set you free. You are so beautiful. Surely you belong to me. I will marry you."

He took her by the hand and led her deep into the forest. At first she tugged against his hand. She knew she shouldn't go. But he was gentle and his eyes shone with joy when he looked at her. Step by step they walked on.

He had a house in the deepest part of the forest. He led the moon spirit inside. Slowly, slowly, he began to stroke her long, shiny hair. The moon maiden sighed deeply. She laid her head on his shoulder. Gently he stroked her back. Gently she returned his caresses. For this night, she was his. They slept side by side, breathing in rhythm. The stars pulsed brightly in the sky, while the moon slept with her human lover. The night was calm, as if even the breeze had gone to bed. Everywhere creatures slept in peace.

But then the sun began to rise in the east, already boiling with rage.

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When Aruako opened his yes, he shivered. Then he remembered. The moon maiden! He reached across the sleeping mat, but her warmth and smooth skin were gone. The lovely spirit of the moon had left him. He ran through the forest calling her name. He dove into the pond and searched among the rocks at the bottom. Nowhere could he find her.

The sun grew fiery, pouring his hot anger onto Aruako. Soon Aruako was dizzy with the heat. Staggering, he fainted. Then he woke up and began to crawl on his hands and knees toward his village. The earth seemed to well up as if it had turned into sea swells. The heavy hot air almost suffocated him.

Two boys found him collapsed upon the path to the village. He was barely breathing. They ran to tell the villagers.

Aruako's skin was pale and dry. His eyes rolled back in his head. "He's terribly sick," said a woman. "Bitten by an adder snake, he was. No one survives that. Or maybe he has sun sickness."

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"Lift him," commanded the chief's son. "Carry him home."

"Do what you can for him," the chief told Aruako's family. They prepared cool compresses of water-soaked leaves. They brought him food and water, but he was too sick to eat or drink. He lay nearly lifeless in the shade. His eyes fluttered open. He tried to swallow sips of water. Girls fanned him with palm fronds. His mother and sisters sat near and sang healing chants softly near his ears.

But the sun rose ever higher and hotter in the sky. Light sneaked under the palm-leaf fans, burning Aruako's skin. His skin blistered and bubbled and then turned black and dry as charcoal in a dead fire. The tears in his eyes dried up. His tongue swelled and filled his mouth.

"Feel him," said his mother to her sisters, looking fearfully up at the sun. "He is boiling inside. The sun plan to kill him. See how it sneaks under our fans and destroys the shade!" All day poor Aruako lay there, sicker and sicker, weaker and weaker.

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Finally, the sun was satisfied. It sank down to the western horizon and slipped over the edge of the world. The moon with her gentle glow ucovered her lovely face. But it was too late for Aruako. Just as the moon peered lovingly down at him, he died. Today the people of his village turn their faces away from the moon. They remember the jealousy of the sun. They will not risk his wrath by gazing too long on the face of his beloved moon.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Beret E. Strong (editor, et al)
Book: Pacific Island Legends
ISBN: 978-1573060844
Publisher: Bess Press, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): August 1999

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier